

SENGIS

Formerly known as elephant-shrews, sengis form a single family. They are superficially similar to the true shrews, although they are not related.

Distinguished by an elongated, flexible snout, sengis are small, with long legs and tail. They move either on all fours or, especially if they need to move fast, by hopping. Sengis live in pairs within a defined area, although there is little interaction between the partners. Males and females even sometimes make separate nests, each defending the jointly held territory against intruders of its own sex. Active mostly by day, many sengis maintain a network of cleared paths around their territory, which they patrol for prey and use as quick escape routes if threatened.

Found only in Africa, sengis occupy a range of habitats, from forests and savanna to extremely arid deserts. Some take shelter in rock crevices or nests of dried leaves, while the larger species dig out shallow burrows.

Sengis are primarily insectivorous, although some species take spiders and worms. They use their sensitive nose to root on the ground and under leaf litter for food, extending their long tongue to scoop up their prey.

ACTIVE YOUNG

Depending on species, a pair of sengis may breed several times during the year. Litters are small, numbering between one and three young, which are well-developed at birth and rapidly become active.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	MACROSCOLIDIDEA
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	20

DEBATE

AN ORDER OF THEIR OWN

In the past, sengis have been linked with shrews and hedgehogs, rabbits and pikas, and even ungulates. Now in their own order Macroscelididae, genetic evidence suggests their closest relatives are tenrecs and golden moles in the order Afrosoricida.

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The Macroscelididae occur in a wide range of African habitats, from deserts to mountains to forests. Largely insectivorous, sengis (or elephant-shrews) use their elongated, moveable snout to search for prey, which they flick into the mouth with the help of their tongue.

